STEADFAST MEN

Lesson 06 · Go First

Transcript · Wes Hart

Hey. Good to see you. Uh, some of you took the same chair as the last lesson. Didn't even look around. I don't blame you. These other chairs have a reputation. Glad you sat down. You're in the right place. Last lesson we sat with the weight. The part that has your name on it. You don't slide that onto somebody else and then call it peace. This lesson is about who moves first. The weight stays. Somebody still has to start.

If you slipped in after we started, I'm Wes. Glad you're in the chair. Now listen. I don't want this to sound like I'm mad at the room. I'm not. A lot of you care. You care about your house. Your kids, if you have them. The men around you. The work in front of you. Caring was never the shortage. I have cared and— I have cared and stalled in the same hour. Uh, I can see the thing that needs a man and still wait, hoping somebody braver will, you know, walk into it. I have hoped that for years. Sometimes, uh, he shows up. A lot of times he doesn't, because he's in his own chair doing the same math. Everybody in the room can already see the thing. Seeing it was never the hard part. So the move has a plain name. Go first.

Some of the men I trust most would rather skip the microphone. They just, uh, hate leaving people stuck. That's the courage I'm talking about. Uh, a man who will start the thing even when he'd rather stay in the chair. You move while it still costs you. You move while your heart is loud. And you move knowing, I mean, you are not alone out front.

I'll put a picture on it. Then I'm gonna ask you for one real door. In a real room. With real people.

One sentence holds four marks of a real man. I have not found, uh, a cleaner list. Here they are. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's.

You've heard this list in here already. The last lesson was that second line, picks up the weight. In this lesson the line in front of us is the next one. He goes first.

Stay with me on that word. First. Uh, I used to think it meant I felt steady. I don't feel steady. The men I have watched go first usually look a little uneasy doing it. Not a show. Just a man who would rather sit, and doesn't. You don't wait around to feel brave. You move, and the feeling can come later, or never come at all. Let me say what I think the word means with jobs and houses and ordinary days. Courageous leading is a move, not a mood you sit and wait on. It is going— it is going first when going first will cost you.

I mean the kind of first that other people can see. You step into the thing the room is avoiding, and you stay there long enough that another man has somewhere to stand. A title, uh, can sit perfectly still. A loud voice can fill a building and still be waiting on somebody else. I have done both. Uh, I have looked like I was leading because I was the one talking, and the whole time, uh, I was hoping the hard sentence belonged to somebody else. So if you remember one line from this part, remember this. Go first when going first will cost you.

That's the mark. The rest is us getting honest about where we've been standing.

Men hear the word leadership and a picture shows up. For some of you, uh, it's a microphone. For some of you it's a name on an office door. For some of you it's the man who sends the schedule and keeps the list. I have wanted every one of those on days I, you know, wanted cover. Cover feels like leading. You can send a— you can send a very clear message about what everybody else ought to do. From over here, I am very inspiring. My own message, I, uh, leave in draft. That's managing. The list moves. You don't. And hear this, because some men get it twisted. Going first is not taking over. It is not winning the room, or making everybody smaller so you can feel large. That is fear dressed up like force. If people leave smaller because you moved, You used them. Jesus, uh, does this a different way. John ten, verse four. When he has brought out all his own, he goes on ahead of them, and his sheep follow him because they know his voice.

He goes on ahead. They follow a voice they already trust. Uh, stay with that. The people around you already know your voice. They have heard it when the money was tight. They have heard it when you were angry. They have heard it when your attention left the room and your body stayed. If that voice and the direction don't match, they may nod, and they will not follow. So the question under the verse is simple. Can they watch how you do the hard thing, and walk the same way?

If they can't, you're dispatching. You're sending them at something while you stay covered. Leading is you already in it, with room beside you.

There was a man in a group I sat in for a long time. Quiet man. Uh, I'll call him Emmett. His dad died, and the dad had a storage unit full of a life. Tools. A workbench taken apart. Boxes the sons had, uh, been meaning to open. Every brother had the code. Uh, that was as far as it went. They would text about getting over there. Somebody would say this ought to happen. Then the thread would turn into ballgame scores. I have sent that text. I am undefeated at the group text that feels like work. Emmett stopped sending them. One Saturday, uh, he drove over by himself. He didn't ask if it was a good day for it. He told me later, uh, his hand was clumsy on the lock. The lock stuck on him. He almost shut it and left. He got it open anyway. The heat came out with the dust. He didn't make a— he didn't make a speech at the doorway. He started lining his dad's wrenches up on the floor, the way the old man had kept them on the bench. Then he took a picture of the wrenches. Sent it. No paragraph under it. A younger brother was there before the first box was finished. Walked up and said, you started. Emmett said, somebody had to.

They stayed until the light was gone. Another brother showed up and just started carrying boxes. Nobody thanked Emmett, uh, with a speech. Here's what I want you to see. Those men were not short on love. They were short on a man already inside, with his hands dirty, where the rest of them could stand.

That's courageous leading. A first pair of hands. The storage unit got empty because one man opened it while it was still easier to leave it shut.

Your version is probably smaller than a storage unit. That's good news, and it's also the trap. Small rooms are easier to postpone, because, you know, nothing looks urgent. I learned that at my own table. I got, uh, smooth. We'd sit down to eat, and I'd look at one of my kids and say, one of you thank

the Lord. They learned, uh, the cue. I called it— I called it raising them. Uh, giving them a chance to grow. One of them finally looked at me and said, you never do it.

Wasn't angry. Just, you know, reporting. I prayed that meal with my ears hot. The words came out clumsy. The roof stayed on. That was me going first in a room that could check my work.

I kept praying at that table after. Short ones. Clumsy ones. One of the kids smirked once. I stayed. Uh, that smirk was the test. If you quit there, the old cue comes right back. A big room will let a man fake the voice. Your people will not. If you want to be steady up front and you go quiet where they know you, the sizes are backward. If you live on your own, the check is still there. It's the friend who actually knows your life, or the drive toward worship when nobody is riding with you. You don't wait on a wife. Your life already needs a man who starts. Start where your voice can be checked. Your table. Your car. The few men who would notice if you hid. A question can be, uh, you going first, if you are actually in it. Where have I made your life heavier. Where have I gone quiet on you. You ask it, and you keep your hand on the door while they answer. What you don't do is borrow their courage and call it training.

I have also, uh, built apologies with a hinge in them. I'm sorry I was short with you, but you don't know the day I had. The sorry walks in. Then the but— then the but sits down and takes the stand back. She can hear the hinge before I finish the sentence. I once sat, uh, in my own driveway and practiced the clean version out loud. No but. No day. No explanation. I gave the whole thing to the dashboard. The dashboard forgave me immediately. Then I walked toward the house, and the but tried to come with me. I stood there and I— I almost let it. The courageous part was leaving it in the car.

What I almost carried inside was a whole account of my day. The drive. The pressure. How I get when I'm tired. None of it belonged in the apology. Uh, she did not need the story of my day. She needed the sorry to stop. I have owed that same clean sentence to a friend. I withheld it and called the silence kindness. Kindness was me staying comfortable. A clean apology ends. I'm sorry. I was wrong. I was short, or I was gone, or I was harsh. And then you stop talking. You do it, uh, early, while you could still win the argument by waiting her out. I have waited her out. My wife could tell you. I called the silence, uh, a cool-down. It was me protecting a win. If the marriage already broke, the same door still exists. Maybe the straightest apology you've ever managed, said to the mother of your kids, and then you leave what she does with it in her hands. You don't control the answer. You do decide who opens.

Uh, history can be real. You still go first. Slow, if slow is honest. First anyway.

There's another door, and it, uh, looks like nothing. It's the true thing everybody can see and nobody will say. We had a slow leak under the bathroom sink. I became, uh, the man who emptied the bowl. Every morning. Very faithful. Uh, I would not say the sentence. The trap is shot. We have to open the cabinet and deal with it. Emptying the bowl felt— emptying the bowl felt like handling it. It was me refusing to name it. Your house, uh, has a version. The money nobody will look at straight. The temper everybody works around. A habit the whole place steps past. Or you stopped gathering with God's people, and the house treats that quiet as normal. Once it has a name, you can do something. Leave it unnamed and it just becomes the way the place looks. So we give the waiting a decent name. Let me see a show of hands. How many of you have given your hiding a respectable word? Go on. This room can handle it. Yeah. Put them down. I'm in there too. One decent name, uh, is humility. I don't want to

be the man who always decides. Sometimes that sentence is true. A lot of times it is me, afraid to be wrong, so I pick nothing and call it character. Another name is coaching. I'll just ask questions and let them get there. A real question is a door you hold open. Coaching, the way a lot of us use it, is a seat that never stands up. You look involved. You never set a direction, and you never name a wrong. And another name, letting her lead. Sometimes that is respect. Sometimes she has been leading because you would not, and you started calling your absence a gift.

Right? If the decent name is the only thing keeping the door shut, drop the name.

I want to be honest, uh, about why the hand stays put. I have given in, uh, to all of this. You are afraid of looking foolish. The prayer comes out younger than you are. Your voice, you know, does a weird little turn, and you hear it, and you want the sentence back while you are still saying it. You are afraid of being refused. You offer the true thing and the other person stays where they are. You stepped out, and nobody stepped with you. That sting is real. I will not talk you out of it. You are afraid of being wrong. So you keep, uh, every option open. A man can feel very open-minded while he refuses to choose. And you are afraid of the cost, because there is one. First pays. You might give up the argument you were winning. You might give up the picture of yourself as the steady man who never starts the hard thing. Count the cost. Then go anyway.

Scripture does not tell a man to wait until the fear leaves. Second Timothy, chapter one, verse seven. For the Spirit God gave us does not make us timid, but gives us power, love and self-discipline.

Timid means the fear got the last word and you stayed put. Courage means you moved while the fear was still talking.

I have waited for my pulse to settle over a sentence as small as, can we talk before you head out. Uh, the pulse did not settle. It still doesn't. You talk with the noise in your ears.

At work, uh, we sat in a meeting and the plan had a hole in it. I saw the hole. I looked at the man running the meeting, and I waited. He moved on. I told myself it— I told myself it wasn't my place. The hole left with all of us. What I called respect was me keeping my own quiet safe.

Here's the part that, uh, changes the door. You are not the first one through it. Uh, I forget this when my hand is actually on the handle. I start acting— I start acting like the whole thing depends on my nerve. My nerve is a poor engine. Rehearsing the whole talk is just delay with a serious face on it. Uh, what moves a man through the doorway is not a surge of nerve. It's remembering who is already in the room. He is not shocked by a shaking voice. He is not waiting on you to feel qualified. You can be the first human through that door and still be second. Deuteronomy thirty-one, verse eight. The Lord himself goes before you and will be with you. He will never leave you nor forsake you. Do not be afraid. Do not be discouraged.

Goes before you. Your hard sentence lands in a room where He is already standing. The clumsy prayer. The apology with the hinge left outside. The true thing you have been walking past. You are walking into a presence, not into an empty quiet.

You are never actually first. You are the second door open.

It still costs. You are still out in the open. He is not leaving.

There's another mark on that list. Works for God's pay. Not the room's. Uh, that one is real. I'm leaving it where it is today. I only need you to know why a man can move when his nerve is thin. Somebody already went ahead of him. And that Somebody can be trusted with what the moving costs.

Uh, nerve runs out. The promise does not. So you don't have to become a fearless man before you are allowed to start. You have to be a man who will move behind a Lord who is already there.

Men, uh, hide by trying to write the whole conversation before they open their mouths. I have written some— I have written some beautiful ones in my head. I mean, they went on for a while. Uh, very fair to me. Very understanding on the other end. And then I never had the real one. You need a first sentence. Not the speech. One line, and then you stop trying to manage what they do with it. You can borrow these if you need them. I was wrong this morning. Before we eat, I'm gonna pray. Something in this house is breaking, and I don't want us to walk past it. Can I ask you a thing I've been avoiding? Pick the line that fits your actual room. Say it. Then do the part we skip. There is a gap after a true sentence. It feels longer than it is. Uh, your body wants to fill it. Explain. Add the second half. Laugh it off. Take it back. Don't.

Stay eight seconds. Count them in your head if you need a rail to hold. Eight. You can live through eight seconds.

I have not always. I have bailed on my own sentence and then stood there confused about why the room didn't change. He is already in the room. Stay anyway.

And do it on an ordinary day. Not when a crisis removes your choices. A regular meal. A regular ride. Uh, a regular morning when letting it slide would be easy.

I had one of my kids in the car and a real question in my mouth. The kind you only get while the road is doing some of the work. I asked what they wanted from the drive-through. We laughed. We got home. The real question rode back with me, still unsaid.

I think about that ride more than I want to.

How many of you already know the sentence, and you've just been saving it? Let me see them. Yeah. That sentence is probably your door.

Uh, young men. If you have been hoping she will decode you, Ask her plainly. Say where you're headed. A woman should not have to guess the man. If there's no wife in the house, you are not stuck in a hallway waiting on permission. You already have a life. Set a direction for it. Be the one who treats worship as real and then is already in the car. Marriage is good. Courage starts in the life you have. Uh, husbands. She should not have to file a request for your attention. You go first. I'm talking to my own pocket when I say the phone can wait. If you took a real hit, if the house went quiet, if the papers are signed, go slow, and go first anyway. The door is still yours to open. Uh, older men. The younger man is not gonna start the walk. You are. Whatever room you are both standing in, you speak first. And if the job is going well, and the room keeps nodding, don't confuse a nod with courage. If you can see the thin place in the plan, say it while saying it still helps. First costs more than a nod. I watched an older man go first in a small way. I'll call him Harlan. He came early to a room where a few of us met. Stood by the doorway on purpose. Watching for the quiet one. He spoke first. How's it going on

the inside. One morning a younger guy tried to slide by with, fine. Harlan said, try that again. I'm not in a hurry. They stood there. The younger man talked. Uh, Harlan didn't have a title on his shirt. He had a first sentence, and he did not rescue the quiet after it.

The younger man was never gonna start that. Harlan knew. So he went first.

Let me bring this home. Here is, uh, the whole thing. A man goes first when he walks into the thing everybody else is waiting on, and he stays through the quiet after, because the Lord himself goes before him.

What I hope— what I hope you carry out of the chair is one room, the people in it, and the words you are gonna open with. Uh, your workbook is where this gets particular. In a minute you'll sit at the tables and work this part together. So get the questions, uh, in your ear. What is the room? Who are the people in it? And what has to happen first? What decent name have you given for holding that door shut? Humility. Coaching. Letting her lead. Say the one you have actually been using. What are the opening words? And will you stay through the eight seconds?

Name it out loud at the table. Write the words where your eyes will find them. Then one door. Pray out loud, in the room that knows you. Or a clean apology, and let it end. Or say the broken thing the people have been walking past. Or a Sunday drive, and you are the one who goes. Or walk toward a younger man. He is not gonna be the one who starts. Stay the eight seconds. I mean, tell a brother the exact words before you use them. Afterward, tell him how it went. Include those eight seconds. If he can't ask you whether you hid, you told the wrong man. And write this where you'll see it. The Lord himself goes before you. You are never actually first. You are the second door open.

The marks still stand. A steadfast man stops waiting, picks up the weight, goes first, and works for God's pay, not the room's. Today, lead. Go first. Tables are yours. Work that part of the workbook together. I'll be around.